

POLISCI 299A
Spring Quarter 2017
Tue 1:30-4:20pm
Encina Hall West, Room 400 (GSL)

Instructor: Adriane Fresh
Office hours location TBD
Office hours by appointment
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Research Design

Spring Quarter 2017
Department of Political Science
Stanford University

Course Description

How do political scientists know what they know? How can you apply these strategies to answering a question about the political world that you are curious about?

This course pursues two simultaneous and interrelated goals. First, students learn to evaluate the scientific research process in the written work of other scholars. To this end, we'll read collections of scholarly papers that each tackle a similar question — what are the consequences of oil for democracy? What effect did European colonialism have on economic development? — but which use different research methods and designs to answer those questions. This will allow us to think about the strengths and weaknesses of the different approaches. You will learn to identify the questions that political scientists ask, the ways in which they build upon theory and the findings of others, and the strategies that they use to gather and evaluate evidence. You will further develop your ability to identify key challenges to drawing conclusions — inferences — from evidence that, while not exclusive to the political world, nevertheless make research in political science one of the most difficult to undertake.

Second, students will develop a research proposal of their own. This proposal begins by identifying a research question that is both answerable — feasible in the context of a senior thesis — and worth answering — that contributes meaningful knowledge of the political world. To this end, you will propose and refine a research question, read the existing scholarly literature related to that question, and gather preliminary evidence that helps to answer the question. The final research proposal (and associated presentation) are designed to be both an exercise in writing a social scientific paper and a stepping stone towards subsequent thesis work.

Course Structure

To fulfill the dual goals of the course described above, the course is structured in two parts. One part of each week's class will be spent engaging with the scholarly work of others. During that class time we'll learn how to identify and evaluate key aspects of political science research. The second part of each week's class will comprise a workshop during which we'll make progress on individual student research projects. Topics for this workshop will be largely determined by

students' projects and progress.

Course Objectives

By the end of this course you, as a student, will be able to:

1. Identify the research questions asked by political science scholars, and develop your own political science research question that is both answerable and worth worth answering;
2. Identify and evaluate the scholarly foundations of the work of political science scholars, and synthesize findings related to your own research question in a literature review;
3. Identify and evaluate the strengths and limitations of that evidence in the work of political science scholars, and gather appropriate evidence to answer your own research question;
4. Identify some of the key challenges to making inferences about the political world both in the research of others as well as your own research, and employ strategies that help to overcome those challenges;
5. Communicate your own social scientific analysis both orally and and writing.

Assignments

There are a variety of assignments that will be used to assess your progress towards the above learning goals. A brief description of each is provided below. Please note that no single assignment constitutes the majority of your grade. Moreover, three of the assignments (as well as the presentation), build towards the final research proposal. More information on the below assignments will be provided when each is assigned in class.

To submit your assignment, please send a Word document by the beginning of class on the specified due date. Extra appreciation will be given for assignments whose files are named *LastName_FirstName_AssignmentName.doc*.

Class Participation + Leading Discussion. 30%

The seminar environment depends on students who are prepared for class and who are actively engaged for its success. To that end, a significant portion of your grade depends on whether you have completed the reading and assignments before you arrive to class, your ability to both offer quality contributions to discussion, and your ability to listen to and engage with the contributions of your fellow classmates. More on the evaluation of participation is provided later in the syllabus.

In addition, each student (in consultation with the instructor) will select 2-4 readings related to their research question and lead a discussion on those readings. All students will therefore have the chance to read important works related to their own research question as well as the research questions of their fellow students. Leading discussion is informal and entails reading and thinking about the assigned papers deeply and bringing questions and comments to pose to your fellow students.

Research Question Memo. Due April 18. 5%

In no more than 2 double-spaced pages, identify a research question about the political world that you would like to pursue during this class. The research question should be both answerable and worth answering. In addition, it should attempt to satisfy the definition of a “good” question that we’ll discuss in depth in class. State your research question clearly in one sentence. If your question is a narrower or more focused part of a broader question, state the broader questions as well. Finally, motivate why you think that the question is worth answering.

Literature Review. Due May 16. 10%

Making a contribution to knowledge about the political world requires a firm grasp on what the scholarly community already knows about the answer to your research question or similar questions. In no more than 5 double-spaced pages, review the most important scholarly works related to your research question. You will likely review 5-10 individual works in the allotted pages. For each work, *very* briefly describe the question that the author(s) ask, their argument (theory) about the answer, the evidence that they bring to bear, and the key limitations of their research that are relevant for your project. Learning to do this concisely for each work is essential. In doing so, your literature review should articulate why we do not yet know the answer to the research question you have set out to ask.

Preliminary Empirical Analysis Memo. Due May 30. 10%

This assignment comprises 3-5 pages double-spaced pages that offer some preliminary evidence that helps you to answer your research question. This must be original evidence that you have collected and/or analyzed yourself as opposed to a description of the findings of others. The memo should begin with a re-statement of the research question. Next the memo should offer a hypothesis about the relationship between (at least) two variables, and a very brief explanation for why you anticipate that relationship (causal logic). Next, describe how and from where you collected the evidence, any coding choices that you made, and the analysis that you performed on the evidence (regression, comparative cases, etc.). Finally, describe in brief the results from performing that analysis. A well chosen plot and/or figure can be included to illustrate the results.

Research Proposal Presentation. June 6. 10%

During the last 1-2 weeks of class, you’ll present your final research proposal. In the presentation, you’ll describe the research question that you’ve identified that has not been fully answered in the existing literature, how the previous literature has tried to answer the question (including its limitations), and your empirical approach to answering the question (including preliminary analysis that you’ve performed). Plan to present for approximately 15 minutes with an additional 15 minutes for questions and discussion from the instructor and your fellow students.

Research Proposal. Due June 15. 35%

The final project for the class puts together the assignments that you’ve already completed, plus a little more. It consists of a 10-15 page double-spaced research paper that identifies an empirical and/or theoretical puzzle in political science that has not been adequately answered in the existing literature. The proposal then explores an approach to solving that puzzle or issue. The final proposal should include an introduction that identifies the research question and motivates the value of answering it; a literature review that explains the answers to your research question that currently exist and why those answers are insufficient; a theory and/or a set of hypotheses

that propose an answer to the research question and a logic for why that answer should be true; a preliminary empirical analysis that provides some (original) evidence that supports or refutes the hypotheses; and a discussion of specific additional empirical steps that you plan to undertake to help more fully answer the research question. Careful attention to discussing the challenges of inference as they relate to your empirical approach is essential. Finally, because your ideas are only as strong as your ability to communicate them, attention to the quality of your written communication — word choice, sentence structure and overall organization — will contribute towards your mark.

Grading

All assignments will be given a numerical score on a 0-100 scale. These scores will be multiplied by the value of the assignment (see above) and the following scale will be used to assign a final letter grade. Assignments will not be accepted for re-grade.

98-100 A+	88-80.9 B+	78-79.9 C+	below 70 D
93-97.9 A	80-82.9 B-	73-77.9 C	
90-92.9 A-	83-87.9 B	70-72.9 C-	

Participation and Attendance

Attendance

A significant amount of the learning that will be done in this course will come from listening to and engaging with the ideas of your fellow classmates. Therefore, attendance in all class sessions is required and contributes towards your participation grade.

Absences are only excused for illness/health, required school activities (i.e. athletics), and family emergencies. If you anticipate being absent for any of these reasons, please let me know in advance if at all possible.

Participation

Participation is fundamentally a question of quality rather than quantity. Full marks for participation involves the following. You are fully engaged in class discussion and activities. You both listen and contribute actively. You are well prepared for class. Having done more than merely read the material, you have spent time thinking *carefully and deeply* about the material's relationship to other materials and ideas presented in previous classes. Your ideas about the material are *substantive* (either constructive or critical); and they stimulate class discussions. You question in addition to stating, and you do more than simply offering your opinion, but rather ground opinions that you may offer in the course materials and ideas. You provide space for other students to share their ideas. You *build* on the contributions of your fellow students, and you listen and respond respectfully.

Email and Appointment Policy

I encourage students to send me questions through email. My commitment to you is to respond to email within 24 hours of receipt. With that in mind, make sure you ask questions related to assignment deadlines well in advance. In return, I also ask that you respond to communications about the class within 24 hours. If you're in doubt about whether an email requires a response, err on the side of sending a simple acknowledgement of receipt.

I also strongly encourage students to request office hours appointments with me and other faculty in the department or the university more broadly. The purpose of the university is research, and by taking this class, you are now part of that endeavor. Engaging with faculty as a scholar-in-training is an exciting opportunity and you're likely to get a lot of thought provoking questions and comments when you share your research projects.

Disability Accommodations

In accordance with university policy, students who may need an academic accommodation based on the impact of a disability must initiate the request with the Office of Accessible Education (OAE). The OAE will provide students who require disability accommodations with a letter describing those accommodations. Students should contact the OAE as soon as possible during the quarter in which they require accommodation. The OAE is located at 563 Salvatierra Walk (phone: 650-723-1066).

The Honor Code

All students are expected to abide by the honor code at all times. I take the honor code extremely seriously, and I will not hesitate to bring violations to the Dean's attention. Abiding by the honor code is a sign of respect to me, your fellow classmates, and to yourself.

The Honor Code is an undertaking of the students, individually and collectively:

- That they will not give or receive aid in examinations; that they will not give or receive un-permitted aid in class work, in the preparation of reports, or in any other work that is to be used by the instructor as the basis of grading;
- That they will do their share and take an active part in seeing to it that others as well as themselves uphold the spirit and letter of the Honor Code.
- The faculty on its part manifests its confidence in the honor of its students by refraining from proctoring examinations and from taking unusual and unreasonable precautions to prevent the forms of dishonesty mentioned above. The faculty will also avoid, as far as practicable, academic procedures that create temptations to violate the Honor Code.

Readings

All readings will be made available on coursework. In addition, students may find it useful to purchase or review two books from which selections are assigned. These are Shively (2013) and King et. al. (1994). This is merely a suggestion, and the books are not required.

COURSE SCHEDULE

WEEK 1

Class 1 – April 4. Introduction and course overview

**** Class location change: Encina Hall West Room 423, RHT Room ****

Key topics and questions:

1. What is this course about?
2. Overview of broad challenges in social science research
3. What is *researchable*?
4. Identifying the research questions of scholars

Readings:

1. Shively, W. Phillips (2013). *The Craft of Political Research*. Boston: Pearson. **Ch1, pages 1-11.**
2. Freedman, David (1991). "Statistical Models and Shoe Leather." *Sociological Methodology*. **Pages 291-300 only.**
3. McRaney, David (2013). "Survivorship Bias." *www.youarenotsmart.com*.
4. Kalesan, Bindu et al. "Firearm Legislation and Firearm Mortality in the USA: A Cross-Sectional, State-Level Study." *Lancet*.

WEEK 2

Class 1 – April 11. Patterns, correlations and inference (*Natural resources and regime type*)

Key topics and questions:

1. What types of patterns can exist in the world?
2. What does it mean to make inference from patterns?
3. Refining your research question
4. How to motivate a research question

Readings:

1. Shively, W. Phillips (2013). *The Craft of Political Research*. Boston: Pearson. **Ch2, pages 14-32.**
2. Friedman, Thomas (2006). "The First Law of Petropolitics." *Foreign Policy*.
3. Ross, Michael (2001). "Does Oil Hinder Democracy?" *World Politics*.
4. Haber, Stephen and Victor Menaldo (2011). "Do Natural Resources Fuel Authoritarianism?" *American Political Science Review*.

WEEK 3

Class 1 – April 18. Choosing and analyzing cases (*Democracies and war*)

**** DUE: RESEARCH QUESTION MEMO ****

Key topics and questions:

1. The strengths and limitations of case studies
2. How to select cases
3. Approaches to evaluating case study evidence

Readings:

1. King, Gary, Robert O. Keohane and Sidney Verba (1994). *Designing Social Inquiry*. **Ch4, pages 115-149.**
2. Reiter, Dani and Allan Stam (2002). *Democracies at War*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press. **Selections TBD.**
3. Desch, Michael (2002). "Democracy and Victory: Why Regime Type Hardly Matters." *International Security*.
4. Lindsay, Carrie Lee (2015). *The Politics of Military Operations*. **Pages 5-8 and pages 91-103 (*skim only* pages 103-142 to get a general sense for the evidence).**

WEEK 4

Class 1 – April 25. Student led discussion 1

Readings:

1. *To be determined in advance by the discussion leader.*

WEEK 5

Class 1 – May 2. Student led discussion 2

Readings:

1. *To be determined in advance by the discussion leader.*

WEEK 6

Class 1 – May 9. Student led discussion 3

Readings:

1. *To be determined in advance by the discussion leader.*

WEEK 7

Class 1 – May 16. Exogeneity and endogeneity (*Colonialism and economic development*)

**** DUE: LITERATURE REVIEW ****

Key topics and questions:

1. Methods for establishing causality in observational studies
2. Integrity in social science research
3. Quantitative historical social science

Readings:

1. King, Gary, Robert O. Keohane and Sidney Verba (1994). *Designing Social Inquiry*. **Ch5, pages 185-196.**
2. Acemoglu, Daron and Simon Johnson and James Robinson (2001). “The Colonial Origins of Comparative Development: An Empirical Investigation.” *American Economic Review*.
3. Albouy, David (2012). “The Colonial Origins of Comparative Development: An Empirical Investigation: Comment.” *American Economic Review*.
4. Lee, Alexander and Kenneth A. Schultz. “Comparing British and French Colonial Legacies: A Discontinuity Analysis of Cameroon.” *Quarterly Journal of Political Science*.

WEEK 8

Class 1 – May 23. Empirical analysis lab

Key topics and questions:

1. Analyzing empirical data

Readings:

1. *To be announced*

WEEK 9

Class 1 – May 30. Strategic interactions among political actors (*Credible threats*)

**** DUE: PRELIMINARY EMPIRICAL ANALYSIS MEMO ****

Key topics and questions:

1. Selection, strategic behavior, and counterintuitive relationships
2. Rational actors and explicitly structured interactions (game theory)

Readings:

1. Fearon, James (1994). "Signaling Versus the Balance of Power and Interests: An Empirical Test of Crisis Bargaining Model." *Journal of Conflict Resolution*.
2. Trachtenberg, Marc. (2012). "Audience Costs: An Historical Analysis." *Security Studies*.
3. Tomz, Michael (2007). "Domestic Audience Costs in International Relations: An Experimental Approach." *International Organization*.

WEEK 10

Class 1 – June 6. Final student presentations of research proposal

FINALS WEEK

June 15 by 5pm – DUE: FINAL RESEARCH PROPOSAL